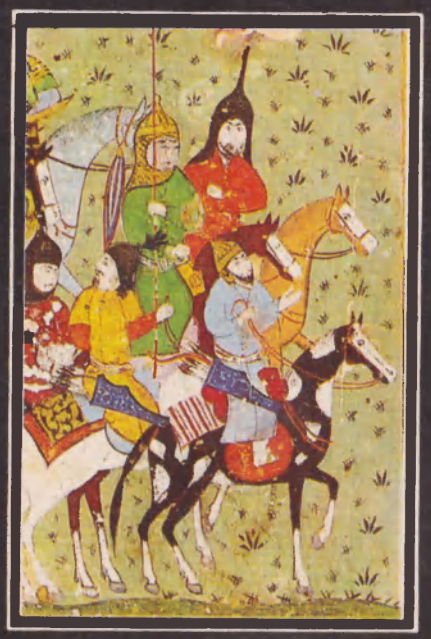
85.143(4)
M-61

MINIATURES

of Central Asia



Miniatures
of Central Asia

223228

17
85.143(Y)
M61

MINIATURES

of Central Asia

Editorial office of Encyclopaedias

Tashkent

БИБЛИОТЕКА
Э/К ФОНД

ИБ №124

ISBN 5-89890-092-6

© Editorial office of Encyclopaedias

$\frac{4402000000}{358 — 94}$

Miniatures of Central Asia

The manuscript book is one of the great achievements of culture of the Muslim Orient. It existed in the Medieval Europe as well, but since Gutenberg invented his printing machine in the 15th century that has been distributed everywhere, it declined as the skill of making manuscripts. The Orient utilized lithography only by the 19th century and the printed matter appeared even later. But even nowadays, the skill of calligraphy is cultivated here, amazing spectators with richness of colours and elaborate design of scripts.

The Oriental manuscripts are surprisingly diverse in variety of subjects they deal with. Theology, exact sciences, natural sciences, poetry and philology, instructions on various handicrafts and text-books on different disciplines, chronicles and belles-lettres might be found in great quantities in the libraries of the rulers and connaisseurs of art, in madrasahs and civil servants' offices.

The 10th century brought fame to the library of the rulers of Bukhara – the Samanides. According to Abu Ali ibn Cino there were plenty of rooms filled up with manuscript books that he had never met before and that inriched a lot of his information on medicine and philosophy. Outstanding Arab scholar – geographer Yakut, arrived in Merv – one of the main centres of Khorasan (now the territory of Turkmenistan) at the beginning of the 13th century. He found ten book depositories there. "Nowhere in the world, – the tireless traveller writes – have I seen anything comparable in quality and quantity... I enjoyed those books and obtained a lot of useful information from them. My affection towards

books made me give up the desire to see new towns and drew away my attention from my family and children". After Yakut "the most useful part of my book (he means his classic work "Kitab mu'jam al-Buldan") and other ones – is from those libraries".

Oriental manuscripts are the best samples of the creative work of a group of artists and specialists. The book starts with selection of the proper paper, thick, ivory-white that was manufactured in Samarkand. The merchants brought it as far as to the countries of the Mediterranian basin, where it was highly appreciated by the masters of Italian Renaissance. First the calligraph — a master of hand-writing started. By the end of the 16th century eight main styles with several variants have been elaborated already.

The text was placed in the framed space, it might have been written on the whole page or divided into two columns, sometimes lines were placed horizontally, sometimes obliquely. The titles were marked out by different hand-writing and colour, in the rich manuscripts gold was used for decoration. Another master specialized in gilding of the margins that were usually decorated with sprinkles of paint or sometimes with a dim floral design, some silhoettes of trees and animals. The main attention was given to the title or two next pages. That is the so-called "unwan" crowned with bright ornament, often with some decorative framing. There was existed a special type of decoration – "sarlaukh" – i.e. richly ornamented circle with inscriptions inside and radial gilded pointers. The last page usually contains the calligrapher's name and the date of completing the manuscript. The last stage – binding, a book-cover was usually made of hard papier-mâché panels lacqued and ornamented or that of the stamped leather with a clasp.

One more way of decorating manuscripts should be mentioned here – that is miniature painting. This kind of decoration is typical of the most precious books that have been specially made for the richest noblemen –

connaisseurs of books. The leading painters-miniaturists were united at the court in the book-making worshops – kitobkhona. Sometimes there were descriptive illustrations specially made for the research books on astronomy, medicine, theology, those which contained axonometrical schemes of the location of the main holy places of Mecca and Medina. Still, that was mainly classic poetry and chronicles that were illustrated. Miniaturists have elaborated certain subjects, compositions and their variants for their illumination.

In the vast territory from Bagdad to Samarkand and later on up to Delhi certain design and colours, composition and types of female and male beauty have been elaborated.

An important role in the process of the development of fine arts in the countries of the Muslim world has been played by the interdiction that according to the hadisses belonged to Prophet Muhammad that prohibited creation of the images of any living being and first of all, — human being, because an artist who created this image was unable to give him a soul, that was only Allah who could do it. As the reaction to it, Oriental ornamentation was gradually developing, its flourishing has been closely connected with the progress of mathematics in these countries. Mastering of various geometric compositions determined endless variety of rectangle, polyhedral, star-shaped and circular forms of ornaments. Floral design has found its development, it was subordinated to the geometric wave-shape, or spiral, or medallions. Finally, one of the leading parts in the decoration of books belongs to epigraphic ornament, in which that is not only contents that attracts attention, but also beauty of its elaborate shape.

Despite of all interdictions, imaginative art has been also developed in the Orient. It may be seen in Medieval ceramics and metalwork, it gained the peak of its perfection in lustre ceramics of Iran of the 12–14th centuries. When Rayy, and Kashan were the leading centres of ornamentation, the main subjects were connected with

poetry and hand-written lines of verses were added to decoration of the picture itself.

Miniature appeared as a part of the art of book–binding at that time. The earliest samples of it have been connected with Bagdad (the so-called Mesopotamian miniature school). Still, orthodox Muslim world of the Arab countries did not accept miniature and its development belongs to the countries of the Orient – Iran, Khurasan, Maver-al-Nahr.

In order to defend themselves from being accused in violation of the religious regulations, the author of one of the books on calligraphy and artists-illuminators addressed to the folllowing postulate – "artists, who create the visual images of a human being and their art "relate to prophet Ali ibn Talib, who enjoyed high respect in the Shiit society.

The 16–17th centuries have been marked by flourishing of the miniatire painting. It coincides in time with the epoch of Renaissance and barrocco in countries of Europe and it might not be a mere coincidence but the reflection of one of those common universal processes of the development of culture that characterize unity of spiritual ideas that emerged in some different places simultaneously but preserved their peculiarities in the cultures of various peoples.

Oriental miniature is characterized by several specific features that become stable in the run of centuries. Certainly, any art is full of conventionalities, but in this case they are entirely different from that of the European schools of painting. Oriental miniature is not aware of perspective (it has appeared only in the Grand Mogul miniature school in India that experienced European influence), background and foreplans are of the same scale in it, the principles of creation of space are absent. The horizontal forms are shown as horizontal projections – for example a square or round basin on court-d'honneur will be a rectangle or a circle, when in the European work it would be a trapezium or an oval. The idea of a scale ratio is displaced in miniature – so, a horseman near a castle of a beauty will be equal in size to the height of the ground of

the castle. In the battle scenes the warriors on the front will be the same size as those peeping out of the distant mountains, or musicians with military tubes – karnaj. There is no shade in miniatures – the colours of faces, clothes, green fields, mountain ranges are plain. They do not form the shape. But the colours themselves are bright and diverse, they often contrast with each other underlining their richness, especially in the clothes, and in the greenery of the gardens, in the painting of walls of the buildings and tiled yards.

There is one more specific feature of the Oriental miniature: never mind what historical epoch the personages belong to, their costumes and surrounding will depict that one contemporary with the artist. It might be legendary pre-shah Jamshid, real Alexander the Great or Genghizkhan, their costumes, architecture, details of the everyday life would be reflecting the time of the artist and the place where the miniature has been created.

A cirlce of compositions, connected with certain subjects has been formed by the 15th century. They are: the scene of an official reception in the interior of a palace or in the ground in front of it, a meeting of a couple in the interior, a fight, a battle, a play in chawgan, meetings of lovers on the background of a tree in blossom, scholars' dispute, a ruler's leisure or rest of a literary hero in the nature and some else. Ordinary masters repeated them without any changes, more experienced ones invented some new details or elements, but mainly utilized common schemes. And only the most outstanding artists created some totally individual compositions.

Despite evident conventionality of the miniature, contemporaries apprehended it as reality. A story of Zain al-Din Vocifi, a representative of the jeunesse doree who escaped from Iranian kizilbashes to Central Asia, is very interesting in that occasion. He described a session of majlice organized by Ali Shir Nawai where the representatives of the Herat intellectual elite took part. Kamal al-Din Bihzad, a painter, was among the guests, he presented

Nawai his portrait on the background of a garden in blossom. Nawai was delighted, he asked his guests: – "What are you thinking about while looking at this wonderful work?". One of the persons present exclaimed that he would like to pick a flower from the picture and decorate his turban with it. Another guest marked that his first feeling has been the same, but then he was afraid to frighten a bird that was painted on the miniature. The third rejoined that such an action might cause the wrath of Nawai, whose image is presented on the miniature. The forth exclaimed that he would have bitten him by the stick that Nawai handles on the miniature. The poet was completely satisfied by those high-flown words, he said: "Respected interlocutors succeeded in drilling the pearl of the sense of this work" (i.e. they have realized vital truth and high skill of the artist). Later he presented rich clothes to all of the present and Bihzad was awarded with a horse with complete harness.

The historical background of the development of miniature painting of Central Asia is as following. The last quarter of the 14th – beginning of the 15th centuries have been marked by endless military expeditions and conquests of Timur, who created a vast empire. After his death the state formally headed by his son Shah-Rukh has been divided into several separate estates headed by grand-sons of Timur – for a short period Khalil-Sultan ruled in Mavar-al-Nahr, later on, up till 1449 it was Ulugh-Beg and then he was followed by the other not so distinguished Timurides.

At the beginning of the 16th century the House of Timur was ruined, in some regions of Iran and Khurasan Persian Shahs of the House of Safavides come to power, later it was conquered by a powerful head of the Uzbek dynasty of Shaibanikhan. The latter family kept power in their hands for the whole century, but in the 17th century it has been replaced by another Uzbek dynasty of Ashtarkhanids.

The times of Timur and the members of his House have been marked by considerable progress of various spheres

of culture. Architectural monuments of Samarkand and Shahrisabz, Herat and Mashhad remained as the bright evidence of that times.

The art of miniature still remained one of the priveledges of the noble society. Important historical regional centres – Shiraz and later on Isfahan, Kazvin and Tebriz in Iran, Herat in Khurasan, Samarkand and Bukhara in Mavar-al-Nahr have become the leading centres of its development. Those centres have formed their own artistic schools on the basis of common technology and easthetic principles, one of such schools has been formed in Central Asia.

Documents telling about that school (scholars named it Central Asian, Mavar-al-Nahr or Bukhara) belong to the end of the 14th century, to the time when Timur created his mighty empire with the centre in Samarkand. He collected not only material treasures from the countries that he conquered, but he also brought scholars, architects, artisans, calligraphs and artists from the foreign countries to his capital. Abd al-Hayy, one of the leading miniature painters from Bagdad was mentioned among the latter, he headed the workshop in Samarkand. Since then – tells the witness – no one in Mavar-al-Nahr painted in a manner different from that of Abd al-Hayy. Muhammad al-Khayyam is one of his pupils, known for one of his signed miniatures that is a copy of a miniature by Abd al-Hayy. Later on he moved to Herat, where he was associated with kitobkhona of the Prince Baysunghur, Pir Ahmad Baghi-Shamali is mentioned among his most talented pupils, he has taken his surname after the name of the garden and palace in Baghi-Shamali in the suburbs of Samarkand, where he has made murals glorifying Timur's deeds.

Miniature-painters continued their work in Samarkand during the reign of the outstanding scholar and ruler Ulugh-Beg. Several miniatures on different subjects have been preserved since that time, as well as illustrations to the copy of the "Stellar Tables" of 1437. In these schemes the position of the stars in the constellations are correlated with the images, connected with their Zodiacal names – Sogittarius,Virgo,

Leo, Gemini and others. They are a warrior with a bow, a bare-footed girl, a lion, the scales. By the second half of the 15th century the main centre of miniature painting moves to Herat, where such masters as Mirak-Naqqash, Kemal al-Din Bihzad, Qasim-Ali worked. Though there exists a limited group of miniatures of the 15th century that the scholars consider to belong to the Samarkand school, a big circle of Central Asian miniatures dates up to the 16th–17th centuries. A certain number of them belongs to the collection of the Institute of Oriental Studies under the Academy of Sciences of the Republic of Uzbekistan. We have selected several samples characteristic of the Mavar-al-Nahr school and its masters. The following publication is dedicated to them.

"Fath-Namah" – "A Book of Victories" – that is a title of a small volume (No. 5369). Local poet Shadi is not well known and renouned by the public. His work is a characteristic sample of the Oriental paneguiric literature, dedicated to glorification of the ruler, in this particular case, it is devoted to Sheibani-Khan.

Taking into consideration that the conquest of Herat is not mentioned in the text, the manuscript has been compiled and recopied in Samarkand before 1507. There are seven miniatures, a little faded, inside the book. The subject concerns the events of Sheibani-Khan appearance on the political scenary. Khan is presented in various surroundings: one miniature shows him together with a beauty on the background of a camp tent, the next pages of the book glorify the beauty of the lady, another – in the company of his closest combatants, the last three illustrate his military deeds. For instance, the last miniature is dedicated to the siege of Samarkand, we know about it from the last of the Timur's House – the rival of Sheibani-Khan – Zakir al-Din Babur.

The miniatures are made by a skillful master: his line is clear, colours are intensive and varied. One of the distinctive features of his compositions is in a small number of personages who are also not numerous even in his

compositions dedicated to battles, the landscape is modest, the figures are large in scale and their Uzbek ethnic features are stressed (Mongol eyes and face type, but with rich beard and moustaches). They wear typical woolen hat – white with black bordering, resembling the one still popular with the Kirghiz. Sheibani-Khan's portrait of the late period that has been made in Herat by the great Bihzad himself presents him in a turban and dress of an urban citizen, but his relationship to nomadic traditions is underlined by a lash at his feet.

The next manuscript according to chronological principle is "The History of Abu'l Khayr" by Masud ibn Osman Kuhistani, it has been copied in the 40ies of the 16th century (No. 9989). Exquisite decoration of this book is not occasional, because Abu'l Khayr has been the founder of the Uzbek Royal House that ruled in the steppes of Deshti Kipchak and after the 16th century its power spread over total territory of Mavar-al-Nahr. The scenes that depict different khans surrounded by their noblemen prevail in the miniatures. All the personages are similar and only the following chapter of the book makes it possible to understand who is shown on the illustrations. The images gain some common ethnic features with the contemporaries of the painter originating in Uzbek community. Landscapes serve the background for nearly all the scenes: sometimes it is a meadow or hills where a tent stands. Only one scene – i.e. the scene of funeral thrilled with solemn sorrow – stands apart from all the rest.

Illustrations to the copy of Shahnama by Firdawsi made in 1956 for the ruler of Khvarazm Ish-Muhammad (No. 1811) is one of the masterpieces of the Central Asian miniature painting. As to the miniatures themselves they appeared in the manuscripts much later, sometimes the scholars attribute them by the edge of the 16th–17th centuries, the others – after 1615. It is notable that five miniatures are signed by the artist Muhammad Murad Samarkandi. His surname – "nisba" – tells about his Samarkand origin, the miniatures might have been made in Samarkand, too.

Shahnama has been illuminated by the artists of Iranian speaking countries many times (Mavar-al-Nahr then already belonged to the belingual region of Iranian and Turkic language area). A certain number of favourite subjects, images and compositions have been elaborated by the artists already by that time. Muhammad Murad demonstrates high skill and introduces some innovations even into the most traditional scenes. Usually miniatures occupied the whole page or the bigger part of it. It is not so in the mentioned above copy. The artist has evidently told the calligraph beforehand about where and what size of blanks should be made in the text. Miniatures in the copy are of oblong shape. The most characteristic in this respect are the scenes of fight, where, opposite to the multi-figures in the battle scenes there are only a few warriors fighting with each other. The side figures are seen only in half, that effect creates the feeling that the scene might be developed in both directions. The battle scenes prevail in this book not only because that subject is one of the main in the poem itself, it attracts the artist because it gives him a chance to create pathetic picture of dynamically moving warriors with their swards raised and bows ready to send their arrows. Sometimes he deals with different subjects, telling of everyday life, or even full of psychological tension. The scene of Siyavush's trail by fire, when he, accused by his step-mother, rushes on his white horse through the fire, belongs to the latter as well as the scene of moaning over dead Alexander the Great, or Zu'l-Qarnain ("Double horned") – as he was called in the Orient. The same might be mentioned in connection with the scene of pursuit of Piran from Turan by the Iranian hero Gutars. Piran was forced to climb a mountain and he decided better to die than to be imprisoned and threw himself into the abyss.

In contrast with the clear lineal drawing characteristic of the Herat School, Muhammad-Murad uses sharp outline, his colours are contrasting, bright but gloomy.

Development of Central Asian miniature continued in the

17th century. As the chronicles tell, two artists from Samarkand Muhammad Murad and Muhammad Nadir arrived in Delhi on the egde of the 16th and 17th centuries during the reign of Akbar from the House of the Great Moguls. There is a separate miniature signed by Muhammad Murad in the collection of the Institute for Oriental Studies under the Academy of Sciences of the Republic of Uzbekistan. It presents a handsome young man of noble origin in a costume typical of Indian nobility of that time. But the image itself and the landscape are purely Central Asian.

The history of Jusuf – Joseph and wife Panthephia named Zuleikha in the Muslim interpretation of the legend attracted attention of many poets of Middle East. Poems by Jami were the most renouned, but there existed other versions as well. Miniature artists eageriy illuminated the subjects connected with this story. One of the most popular was the scene when Jusuf's brothers throw him into a well but murchants from the passing-by caravan save him, next scene is that of the Jusuf's arrival in Zuleikha's house, the latter falls in love with him at the first sight, and women, cleaning pomegranates cut their fingers and fall breathless so they have been impressed by his sight.. One more scene is that of Jusuf's temptation by Zuleikha and the refusal of the chaste boy.

There are five miniatures in the copy of the work by poet Durbaq (No. 1433) made in 1615. Action takes place in rural and urban surrounding. Dynamic poses of the participants of the depicted events, asymmetrical composition of the details of landscape and architecture, thick contrast colours – all the details underline common tention of the events that have been described in the poem.

Expressive cycle of miniatures decorate a big format copy of Zafarnamah by Sharaf al-Din Ali Yazdi made in Samarkand in 1628. (No. 4472). There are only seven miniatures in this cycle, but all of them are big, they cover entire page and are most expressive. The artist's manner might be qualified as that of the barrocco style,

so dynamic and contrast in colour it is. The subjects are diverse, but the main attention is given to the scenes of battles and it seems to be natural for the history of Timur's reign. Besides there are some scenes of feasts and even a love scene. The warriors are shown in complex postures and in movement on the background of uneasy landscape with raising mountains and hills where crooked trunks of the trees spread their branches with red leaves as it happens in stormy weather, the sky is covered with golden volute clowds. In the scene of the feast we see the same dynamic structure – complicated postures of the figures, spread branches of the trees, obliquely hanging carpet and fabric of the tent. The artist who illuminated "Zafarnamah" has completely refused from the harmonized compositions of the Bihzad school, and left behind Muhammad Murad Samarkandi. He has been the artist of another century and another aspirations.

Chronicles and signs on the miniatires themselves have preserved for us the names of some artists who worked in Samarkand and mainly in Bukhara. The names of Muhammad Sharif, the already mentioned above Muhammad Murad Samarkandi, Muhammad Darvish Samarkandi belong to the last quarter of the 16th – first three decades of the 17th centuries. The second half of the 17th century during the reign of Abd al-Aziz Khan–II there appeared the names of Muhammad Muqim, Avaz-Muhammad, Muhammad-Amin, Mullo Bihzad. At the end of the century during the reign of Subhankulikhan the list of names has been prolonged by Hwaja Gaday. Muhammad-Amin was not only the master of miniature painting, but he has also made several monumental works, and the murals for Abd al-Azizkhan Madrasah in Bukhara (1652) among them. In this mural he skilfully combines ornamental motives and landscapes of gardens with some architectural sights.

The signed miniatures of the mentioned above artist besides some common features of the style have several peculiarities of the artistic manner. Several stylistic trends might be mentioned in that occasion. One of them might be

called classic, another – romantic, the third is connected with the influence of the Indian miniature, the forth bears some features of the primitive folk art. Artists who belong to the first group continue traditions of exquisite compositions, form and colour that routes in the Herat school headed by Bihzad, though it has obtained specific features of another epoch. The works of romantic artists are marked with some signs of barrocco style, expressed in dynamic forms and contrasts of colours. Some of the artists utilize principles of perspective obtained in the art tradition of Indian Grand Mogul dynasty alongwith the certain ethnic type. Certainly that is only a scheme of characteristic of the mentioned above trends because the leading artists have invented some individual elements into the interpretation of traditional subjects that reflected their artistic individuality.

Muhammad Muqim was one of the most renouned and productive artists during the reign of Abd al-Aziz Khan, a lot of his signed miniatures have been preserved. For instance, he was one of the three miniature artists who illuminated the richly decorated copy of Shahnama from the collection of the Institute of Oriental Studies under the Academy of Sciences of the Republic of Uzbekistan (No. 3463) that has been made for Abd al-Aziz Khan in Bukhara in 1664.

Though the subjects of miniatures performed by Muhammad Muqim are traditional, they are not mere copies of the previously existing ones. Being true ancestors of the classic school of the epoch of Timurides, he looses its exquisite style, the images become more real, they are larger in scale, their poses and gestures reflect vivid reaction on the events, they are free of any pathetic or lyric feeling, that the subject dictates. This artist is more intellectual than emotional. The works of another artist, whose name remained unfamiliar to us, are in contrast with his works for the mentioned above book. The latter continues expressive manner, typical of the illustrations for Muhammad Murad Samarkandi (in his Khiva copy of Shahnama), but on the higher level. It is characterized by

ЗИВЛМОТЕКА
І/К ДІХАД

the choice of subjects – the death of Rustam, killed by the arrow of Shagad, who betrayed him, or Rustam throwing away a huge stone that Bahman dropped on him. They are most expressive and emotional, the background of it is formed by romantic landscape with blue-lilac rocks, meadows covered with the carpet of flowers, crooked trees.

A kind of the so-called democratic style has been formed by the edge of the 17th–18th centuries. It is represented in two copies of the manuscript Majlis al-Ushak. Sultan Hussein Baikara, one the members of the Timur's House, is considered to be its author, though it is known that he has made only a preface and Kamal-al Din Guzurgani is the real author of the book. The title – "Meeting of the Devoted" carries purely Sufique feeling of love and devotion to God, to the sacred origin. The illustrations to the copy contain some scenes of a dispute or moral talk of the pir – spiritural tutor-addressed to the young pupil, sometimes it may be a fable with a moral. Two artists performed miniatures for the copy No. 3475. That particular style has become dominating in the end of the 19th century when, after the deep crisis in the process of the development of culture in Central Asia in the 18th century, it has been transformed into the first printed books made on the basis of lithography.

The samples of miniatures from the collection of the Institute of Oriental Studies under the Academy of Sciences of the Republic of Uzbekistan give general idea of the process of the development of that genre of Fine arts in the Muslim Orient, and the artists of Central Asia have contributed a lot into that process.

SIEZURE OF SAMARKAND BY SHEIBANIKHAN

Mullo Muhammad Shadi. Fath–namah. Beginning of the 16th century

The miniature has been damaged, but it is still interesting as a historical document and a sample of a well–arranged composition. The head of the Uzbek tribes that inhabited the North–West territories known as Deshti–Kipchak—a steppe area of Central Asia—Sheibanikhan successfully conquered the country of the Timurides at the beginning of the 16th century. The main capital city Samarkand protected by the last representative of the Timuride dynasty Zakhir al'Din Babur had been besieged for the long four months by the troops of Sheibanikhan. Decisive attack of Sheibanikhan at the Iron Gate (Ahanin) led to his victory and Babur had to escape.

A double miniature to Fath–namah tells about that event. One can see mighty walls and gates of Samarkand, the last warrior on its walls, but a crowd of citizens is already running through the gates in order to leave the city. The Uzbeks attack them and to the right we see Sheibanikhan sitting on horse and giving commands. Glorious victory has been described by Shadi in the final part of the poem and illuminated by the artist.

SHEIBANIKHAN PAYS A VISIT TO THE "CHARMING BEAUTY"

Mullo Muhammad Shadi. Fath-nama. Beginning of the 16th century

Scene with a couple of lovers or a noble married couple has been widely spread in the miniature of Central East. They are usually presented on the background of a romantic landscape or in a richly decorated interior, or sitting in a beautifully decorated pavilion in some garden in blossom. It is different in this particular miniature – the artist evidently underlines the tribal character of Sheibanikhan surrounding. His visit to the lady who represents one of the noble families finally leads to his marriage, the scene is arranged by the artist in modest landscape of the steppe, where Khan is sitting with his future wife near the hut in the company of her girl-servants, Khan and the rest participants of the scene have Mongolian ethnic type of faces, characteristic of the Uzbeks of Deshti-Kipchak, their clothes and hats are of the same origin. The figures are of large scale, their postures are reserved, but the lineal drawing is precise and colours are rich.

نهاد پس بون زرین بجا
صراحی طلا و پیالهٔ طلا

FEAST IN THE MEADOW

Masud ibn Osmani Kuhastani, Tarihı Abu'l Khayr. 1541

When telling the genealogy of Abu'l Khayr the head of the Uzbek family that lived in Deshti–Kipchak, the author gives the history of the great conquerers of the previous times beginning from Alexander the Great but especially, underlining their family ties with the Genghizides. Though the events shown noblemen and servants, drinks and snacks are in the miniatures have taken place in a distant time from the moment when the copy has been, made appearance, costumes and surrounding are marked with contemporary Uzbek features of the 16th century. The scene above belongs to that type, where Genghizkhan is presented sitting on a golden thrown –takhta, in the sandy steppe with rare grass and flowers. Bright greenery and golden heavens, colourful clothes, various in shape vessels and armour create the total colourful structure of the miniature.

FORTITUDE OF JALAL AL-DIN

Masud ibn-Osmani Kuhastani Tarihi Abu'l Khayr. 1541

The story of Genghizkhan military expedition to Central Asia is full of dramatic situations. In 1219 Khvarazm was conquered, two hundred thousand citizens were killed, the ruler-Khvarazmshah Muhammad escaped. Only his son Jalal al-Din Menkuderdi bravely fought against the enemy, and when he remained alone, he took his sword and was ready to give his life in the battle. According to Tarihi Abu'l Khayr courage of Jalal al-Din caused sincere admiration of Ughedei, a son of Genghizkhan, the head of Khvarazm military expedition. The miniature presents that dramatic episode. The page is divided by Amu-Darya river into two plans, where numerous Mongolian troops oppose the sole figure of Jalal al-Din. The landscape is also based on contrast that serves to underline this contraposition: plain monotonous steppe is the background for multi-coloured group of Mongolian warriors, their picturesque costumes are decorated with great many details, coloured bunchuks, shields, horse-cloths and opposite there is a meadow covered with green grass and flowers, the lonely figure of the brave prince and his white horse.

SYAVUSH UNDERGOES THE FIRE TRAIL

Firdawsi, Shah-nama. Copy of the 1556 miniatures of the end of the 16th century. Artist Muhammad Murad Samarkandi

Syavush, one of the romantic heroes of Shahnama has been accused by his step-mother Sudabeh in inflinger upon her honour. She told so because she fell in love with Syavush. In order to prove his sinlessness he underwent the ancient custom of purification by fire. This subject has been very popular with the artists who illustrated Shahnama.

In the particular copy Muhammad Murad Samarkandi utilizes traditional interpretation of the subject elaborated in the 15th century. Syavush dressed in the white costume of a warrior rushes on his horse through the fire, but it doesn't touch him. The white colour of his dresses is a symbol of purity of the hero, though in Avesta his name Syavush-Syavarshan means "Black horse". Several persons watch the act from behind the mountains.

THE BIRTH OF HARMIZD, A SON OF SHAPUR

Firdawsi, Shahnama. Copy of the 1556 miniatures belong to the end of the 16th century. Artist Muhammad Murad Samarkandi

The birth of a heir in the royal family has been a very important event. The miniature is dedicated to the moment of prince Harmizd's birth in the family of the Sasanide Shah Shapur. The artist presents it as a scene from everyday life. According to the Central Asian and Iranian peoples' tradition characteristic of all the society's stratas, the parents celebrated the happy occasion on the 40th day after the baby had been born: they put the cradle out for the neighbours, relatives and friends to come and see him and bring their gifts and greetings. Certainly, it was a solemn act in the royal family, but the miniature shows it to be a modest ceremony. Still, the cradle–beshik of Harmizd is golden and it is put on the high stand. But the ceremony itself takes place in a modest mountaineous landscape and only the parents and two servants take part in it.

بیامد بکردی زرآن نشست
میان پیش او بندگی را ببست
جهانرا همی داشت با داد و رای
سپه را بهر نیکویی رهنمای

JUSUF'S SALE FOR SLAVERY

Dubraq. "Jusuf and Zuleikha". Copy of the 1615

The action takes place in the urban surrounding. The front plan is occupied by the figures of argueing murchants and curious persons (they are in Central Asian costumes, one of themis in Indian costume), a kneeling old woman is also present there. A rich three–storeyed house occupies the back plan, there is one more building and a mountain behind that house. Jusuf with golden flames behind his head as a symbol of sanctity is standing at the portal of the entrance. A woman is looking at Jusuf from the roof of the house, two other women–servants watch their mistress, who is sitting in a pavilion that crowns the house. That is Zuleikha, who has fallen in love with Jusuf from the first sight.

THE BATTLE OF THE ARMIES OF TIMUR AND TOQTAMISH

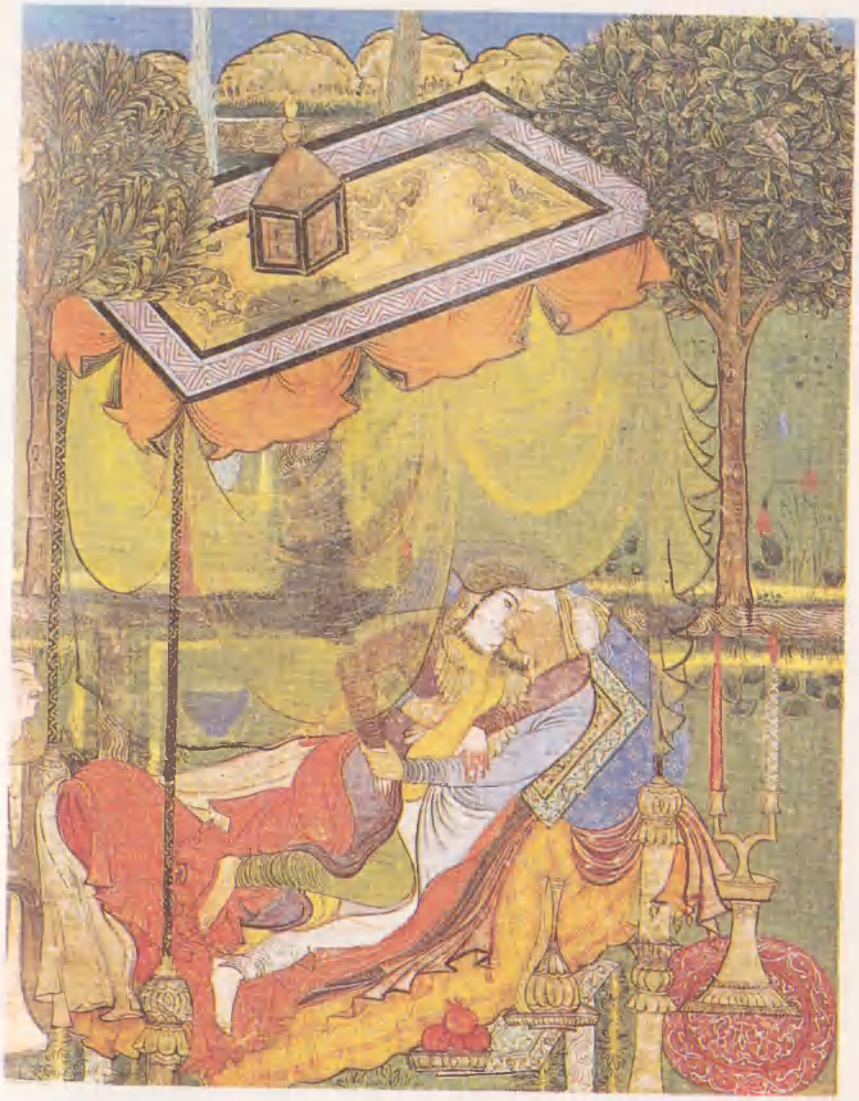
Zafar–Naman' Sharaf al–Din Ali Yazdi. 1628

One of the main military expeditions of Timur was directed against Toqtamish–Khan, the leader of the Golden Horde that has already lost its power but still controlled the territories from Khvarazm up to the Lower Volga River basin and the Northern Caucasus. That was here, where his army was totally defeated. The miniature is thrilled with the feeling of tension of the last battle expressed by means of composition, the lineal movement and contrast colours. The number of participants is not so big but all the figures are in some complex postures, dynamic movement, some of the figures are shown only partially, bordered by the margins, that creates the impression of the development of the composition behind the visual border of the scene. Dynamism of the battle is underlined by the rocky landscape with rows of rocks climbing one over another and the flattened branches of the trees, bowed under the pressure of strong wind. The colours are multi and rich. The victory is already predestined, and it is on Timur's side, the latter watches the battle from a distance.

TIMUR WITH DILSHAD

Zafar–Namah Sharaf al–Din Ali Yazdi. 1628

Erotic scenes are rare in the Oriental miniature because they were morally accused by Islam. Still, the artists neglected that from time to time. In the copy of "Zafar–Namah" such a scene takes place in the night garden. The couple of lovers is presented on the background of a light pavilion covered with golden curtains, inside it is decorated with colourful blanket, feast vessels, pomegranates, chandelier stands nearby. Dark–skinned and dark–beared Timur embrases light–haired beauty Dilshad. A smiling servant watches them from aside.



TIMUR'S RECEPTION

Abdullah Hatifi. "Timur-Namah". 1568

Timur is sitting on the sofa in front of an aivan, decorated with glazed tiles. His face on the miniature has been damaged and the paints faded, but it doesn't seem that the features resembled his true image. The sofa is surrounded by flourishing lawn, the guests sitting on the carpets, on the front sight musicians playing music to entertain the guests, servants are ready to serve wine and dishes. The miniature is performed by an average level artist, who just repeated traditional composition worked out already in the 15th century.

SYAVUSH UNDERGOES THE FIRE TRAIL

Shahnama by Firdawsi. Copy of the 1664. Artist Muhammad Mudim

This subject has been already demonstrated among the miniatures by Muhammad Murad Samarkandi.
Muhammad Muqim gives his own interpretation of this subject. Here the young hero doesn't pass through the fire riding a horse, he is thrown into the flaming by cold flames fire, but it covers him without any harm for him. Amazed spectators are presented on the front plan of the miniature. The image of Syavush as the centre of the entire composition is underlined by his purple clothes and lilac with a broch–egret turban. Columns of the text frame the entire composition and create the synthesis of words and the images.

RUSTAM REMOVES THE STONE THROWN BY BAHMAN

Shah–nama by Firdawsi 1664

The subject of the miniature is connected with the story about young Bahman, a son of Isfendiar, who has been sent to the hero Rustam to convince him to subdue to the Iranian ruler Gushtasp. When Bahman saw the resting hero on his way through the mountains he was so frightened by his mighty that he decided to kill him while the latter was sleeping. He threw a huge stone on him. But the powerful hero pushed it away easily. Besides the main hero there are some other personages on the miniature, they are watching the scene and express their amasenient, that is stressed by the tense postures of the figures and the two horses. Dramatic character of the situation is strengthened by the landscape with rocky mountains, crooked trees and contrast colours.

کسی کو نهد زسنگ و زکوه
کجا گرد از یک سوار ایستوه
بگفت این سخن تیغ بر کار دید
وزان راه آسان سر کرد کشید
چو آمد بنزدیک نخچیر گاه
تنش بد بدیش همانند زاغ
بنخچیر هر کس که بد پیش او کم
بدو گفت رستم که با ما نخیز
وز پهلوان زود در بر گرفت
بلو بر چنین گفت کین مرد کیست
پیاده شد از باره و پیش او
بدو گفت من پور هفتد یار
بر فتند هر دو بجای نشست
من ایدون گمانم که گشتاسپ
بپرسیدش و نیکو بیاموزد
سر بهستگان اهرمن نامدار
خود و نامداران و سر بر سپست

A DISPUTE IN THE BATH

Kamal al-Din Gazurghani. Majlis al-Ushak. End of the 17th century

The title "Majlis ul-ushshak" means "Gathering of Devoted", it does not mean those who are in love, but it is the notion that serves to express the idea of love to God. The book contains various fables and stories connected with outsanding shaikhs, rulers and historic figures where they perform the role of pir-spiritual tutor, who is attentively listened to by his pupils-murids. The miniature is connected with the prominent poet and sufique theologist Saadi Shirazi. The event takes place in the bath and has a character of an everyday-life scene. The centre and the left part are occupied by the picture of the bath constructions, where the visitors and servants are lively chatting with each other. Two visitors to the right sit on a high sofa. An elderly man drinks something from a jug. It may be Saadi himself watching the scene that takes place around.

Галина Анатольевна ПУГАЧЕНКОВА

Среднеазиатские миниатюры

Редактор — *А.И.Кременцова*
Художник — *Н.А.Взенконская*
Художественный редактор — *А.Бурханов*
Компьютерное макетирование — *Д.М.Бурштейн*

Формат 84x108 1/32. Бумага мелованная. Усл. п. л. Уч.-изд. л. 1,5. Тираж 10000 экз. Заказ № 3158. Цена договорная.

Editorial office of Encyclopedias
30, Navoi str., Tashkent - 700029
"Shark" Publishing and Printing Concern
41, Byuk Turon, Tashkent

Galina Anatolyevna Pugachenkova — noted scientist, Doctor of Arts Criticism, Academician of the Academy of Sciences of the Republic of Uzbekistan, honorary member of the International Academy of Architecture of the East, researcher of Arts Heritage of Central Asia. G. A. Pugachenkova — author of over 30 books and 400 articles, dedicated to Architecture, Fine and Applied Arts of the Middle East. One of the subjects of her researcher — Central Asian school of miniature painting. This book is dedicated to this subject.